successfully chased 313 to win at the Wanderers; he is a high-quality cricketer and a high-quality person, a fine ambassador for his country respected throughout the game.

Next stop ... New Zealand.

The game had moved on from the days when a single touring squad would arrive in a country and play a Test series followed by one-day internationals. In 2012, one Proteas side played New Zealand in three T20 internationals, and won the series 2–1. A significantly different Proteas team played the hosts in three one-day internationals, and won 3–0. And then a third Proteas side set about the challenge of playing three Tests.

Of the team that started the first T20 international at the Westpac Stadium in Wellington on Friday, 17 February, only three players – Amla, Morné Morkel and me – were retained and included in the team selected to play in the first Test match at Dunedin's University Oval 19 days later. The rest flew home.

The horses-for-courses selection strategy recognised the twin realities that, first, certain specialist players were better suited to certain formats of the evolving game and that, second, the physical demands of playing in every single international match were stretching some of the more mature players. Even so, something was lost amid the technical and physiological rationale.

The type of international tour that had once seemed such an adventure for a tight-knit group of 16 players, who were bonded by embracing so many different experiences in so many different places, had been transformed into some kind of military operation where, almost every day, someone would pack their bags and take a taxi to the airport and someone else would arrive, bleary eyed, carrying their suitcase into the hotel foyer.

With all the comings and goings, it was increasingly difficult to predict